

AMSTELVEEN, HOCKEY, AND EVERYTHING IN BETWEEN

From bicycles and shoelace disasters to an emotional meeting involving two Indian goalkeepers, the Diary's Amstelveen sojourn offered **plenty** off the turf.

Aashin Prasad

aashin.p@thehindu.co.in

Amstelveen has so far matched expectations: tidy and efficient, much like the Dutch hockey teams at this World Cup. Covering the Indian teams' (mis)fortunes at the event meant setting up camp in this quaint Amsterdam suburb for the first 10 days, putting a visit to the other co-host, Wavre in Belgium, on hold.

Unlike the FIFA World Cup, where matches are spread across the host country, the hockey showpiece had games throughout the day at just two venues. At the Wagener Stadion, where India played all its group matches, the packed schedule left little scope to explore beyond the complex, home to Hoofdklasse club Amsterdam AH&BC.

Amsterdam AH&BC is the oldest hockey club in mainland Europe, with a history spanning 125 years. It has enjoyed so much success that its entire collection of honours can't even fit in the clubhouse's trophy case, with several having to wait their turn to make an appearance. **One of the oldest trophies, jokingly referred to as the 'goblet' from the Harry Potter books, has won the lottery to make the cabinet this time around.**

There is a popular saying in the Netherlands that there are more bicycles than people, and they are hard to miss. If you aren't paying attention, you are arguably more at risk of getting hit by a biker than a car here. Cycling seems to be the preferred mode of commute for the locals, including England midfielder Thomas Sorsby, who moved to the city after recently signing for Amsterdam, which plays its home games at the Wagener.

Travelling supporters from India, England and Australia add colour to the

Moving moment: Bichu Devi and Savita Punia appeared emotional as Caroline Busch, widow of late Dutch goalkeeping coach Simon Zijp, handed them a sealed letter and other belongings. Zijp had trained the Indian goalkeepers since February last year and was due to return in November.

PICS: AASHIN PRASAD